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VICTORIOUS: TMC's party workers celebrating at Nandigram

REVENGE IN NANDIGRAM

The Marxist humiliation in the erstwhile citadels of Nandigram and Singur in the local-body elections is a severe popular rejoinder to the ham-handed reform agenda of the West Bengal Government

■ **By Elora Sen and Shafi Rahman**

It was the site where Comrade Reformer of Indian communism wanted to build his legacy. It was where he wanted to begin his New Bengal project. Then everything went wrong. Nandigram became a landmark in the Marxist bloodlust, and Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya ceased to be the much indulged moderniser, the Bangla version of Deng Xiaoping. The carnage brought out the Stalinist savagery of the party. On May 21, it was as if the ghosts had their revenge.

Since the horrors of November 2007, CPI(M) leaders had been giving lessons on the need to understand the "ground realities" in the West Bengal villages and forecasting a Left victory in

Panchayat polls in Nandigram and Singur. Kicking the apparatchiks of AKG Bhawan off their high moral pedestal, Nandigram has hit back.

It was a clear mandate against the party by the people of Nandigram and Singur, giving Trinamool Congress their first-ever seats in the Zilla Parishads. They won two districts: South 24-Parganas and East Midnapore (including Nandigram), both former CPI(M) strongholds.

The Left Front suffered a major setback with its overall tally in the state coming down to 519 Zilla Parishad seats from 619 in 2003. Trinamool improved its tally from 16 seats to 121 and Congress moved up from 67 seats to 98.

The Congress has fared well in two areas—its stronghold in Malda where Ghani Khan Chowdhury's legacy is still

intact, and North Dinajpur, another Left Front bastion.

This is a huge humiliation for CPI(M). The party has been consistently maintaining that the atrocities in Nandigram and Singur would be of little consequence. The defeat will also weaken CPI(M) efforts to bridle the reform policies of the UPA Government which is entering its last stretch.

For Trinamool leader Mamata Banerjee, this was more than just poetic justice. "This is the beginning of the end for the CPI(M) Government here. The Centre too must take note," she thundered. "Where the ballot could speak, we have done well. The Centre must realise that for 31 years, the Left Front has not allowed a proper election machinery to function. They have not allowed people to vote." Trying to